

A New Normal

A story about warmth, hope, and family, A New Normal explores themes of 'home' and 'belonging' combining elements and processes of traditional narrative filmmaking with augmented reality.

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ABSTRACT

As we learn to keep social and familial connections alive amidst the pandemic and rely heavily on digital media, I realize this has been my own 'normal' for most of the past decade. After immigrating to the US from India, my ability to travel home and be physically present with my family became limited, particularly after the 2016 elections. Thinking about home and belonging today, my thoughts go to my sister in Copenhagen and my parents in New Delhi. Using Augmented Reality as a storytelling tool for this film, allows me to see the evolving definition of 'home' through the eyes of my family. My experiments in early 2020 as an artist in the Adobe Aero AR Residency, helped explore the possibilities and limitations of AR, as experienced through the Adobe Aero application. Following this, I was interested in seeing how AR could fit into the scope of a narrative project and how it would interact with a traditional animation or video workflow when used by a filmmaker. I discovered many efficiencies during the production process, the most powerful being in-camera, real-time compositing. The process of creating 'A New Normal' combines the technical and conceptual workflows of both animation and documentary filmmaking. One scene has been made available to view in AR via the Adobe Aero app on iOS. Shot entirely in my apartment while sheltering in place, A New Normal is a product of remote collaboration between artists based in Copenhagen, Madrid, New Delhi, Mumbai and Los Angeles. In this short, my everyday digital conversations with family are overlaid with AR versions of my parents and sister in my own environment, to co-create a mixed reality experience that for the time being, is the closest thing I have to the feeling of home.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Computer graphics; • Mixed/ augmented reality; • Media arts;

KEYWORDS

Animation, Art, Narrative, Design

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1 INTRODUCTION

The short film created using Augmented Reality, tells a story about warmth, hope, and family. It frames the idea of 'home' and 'belonging' through the eyes of a family that's scattered across different parts of the world. The narrative has been constructed through various interviews with the different speakers, where they express their views about the evolving idea of home and changing family dynamics.

The digital characters (Figure 1) have been created in a bold graphic style to contrast with the realism of the video footage, but still with an attempt to complement the color schemes of the spaces they inhabit. The film is a passive viewing experience.

1.1 Design & Solutions: AR Scene

Following the AR scene (Figure 2) presented along with the film, provides insight into how the film is constructed.

The scene allows the viewer to step inside a particular segment of the film that talks about feeling nurtured and protected in one's home. When viewed through the mobile device, two large hands enter from either side of the main character, holding and supporting her. The space around the hands comes to life with, butterflies, flowers, and elements of nature. The viewer can walk around the scene, observe each moving element closely.

2 APPLICATIONS OF ADOBE AERO IN FILMMAKING

Making an AR film disrupts the usual 2D animation production pipeline. This project has been created in 3 weeks. With minimal pre-production, the team jumped straight into creating final assets that were placed in scenes and animated on the spot in Adobe Aero.

The process of creating 'A New Normal' combines the technical and conceptual workflows of both animation and documentary filmmaking. Using in-camera, real time compositing (Figure 3) cuts down on production time and allows for a less rigid creation process.

Combining augmented reality with a 2D animation production pipeline allowed us to bring in the flexibility provided by live action

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Figure 1: Film Still from 'A New Normal'



Figure 2: AR Scene



Figure 3: Artist placing illustrated assets in an AR scene.

and documentary filmmaking where we the illustrated characters and assets can be treated as actors in a scene. This also allows us to have plenty of leeway to reshoot material that doesn't fit into the narrative.

Time and financial limitations are two of the largest obstacles standing in the way of independent filmmakers. In addition to speeding up production, this new process is pandemic friendly and allows to make the most of the limited spaces and environments available to us.

3 CONCLUSION

Adapting augmented reality apps to adhere to a filmmaking pipeline, specifically in the case of Adobe Aero, should be approached with

an open mind since this is a medium that's in the process of coming into its own.

As this app develops further and offers more scope for bringing in different asset types and animations, there will continue to be more opportunities and new ways to meld different filmmaking processes together, arming independent filmmakers with robust tools for telling truly personal stories.

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